

KY.3 Inspection Sequence

The order inspections happen in, which ones happen no matter where you build, and the clocks Kentucky law runs against the inspector.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Kentucky writes one mandatory residential code for the whole state — and then leaves the building permit, the inspections and the certificate of occupancy to each of its 120 counties and its cities, some of which require them and many of which do not. The state plumbing permit and the electrical certificate of approval apply either way. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

WHY KENTUCKY HAS NO SINGLE LIST OF INSPECTIONS

In most states you can print one inspection sequence and it will be broadly right everywhere. In Kentucky you cannot, because the building inspections and the trade inspections come from different places and only one set is guaranteed.

The trade inspections always happen. Plumbing, HVAC and electrical are governed by statewide instruments that do not care whether your county has a building ordinance. **The building inspections happen only if your jurisdiction requires them** — and in roughly a third of Kentucky counties there is no local building inspector on the state's own list at all. Work out which column you are in before you plan the schedule.

THE APPROVALS THAT HAPPEN WHEREVER YOU BUILD

Always required — whatever your county does about building permits

Inspection	What it covers	Authority
Plumbing — underground / rough	Under-slab and in-wall water, waste and vent piping, under test, before it is covered. Your permit includes five inspections at no additional cost , so use them rather than saving them.	815 KAR 20:050 §5(1)
Plumbing — final	Fixtures set and the system complete. This is the approval a water utility or water district needs before it may give you permanent water .	KRS 318.165
HVAC — installation	The initial heating, ventilation or air conditioning system. The inspection <i>"shall be scheduled with the property owner ... at least one (1) business day in advance and shall be completed within three (3) business days of the scheduled inspection."</i>	KRS 198B.6672(3)

Always required — whatever your county does about building permits

Inspection	What it covers	Authority
Electrical — rough and final	Arranged through the certified electrical inspector for your county. The final certificate of approval is the document your power company needs before it may connect permanent electric service .	KRS 198B.060(11)

The two signatures the whole schedule hangs on

Whatever else happens, your house does not become habitable until two people sign. A **certified electrical inspector** issues the final certificate of approval — and *"after a certified electrical inspector has been provided for by the local government or the department, no utility shall initiate permanent electrical service to any new building"* without it. (That opening condition is met in practice: all 119 published county sheets name a state electrical inspector.) And the plumbing is inspected and approved, without which *"no permanent water supply shall be provided to any building by any public utility or water district."*

On a septic site there is a step in front of the electrical one. A certified electrical inspector may not issue a certificate for temporary or permanent wiring without a **notice of release** from the local health department — the initial release on your septic site-evaluation application, the final release on approval of the sewage disposal plan. So the health department gates your construction power too, unless your county has adopted the Uniform State Building Code and enforces on-site sewage permitting. (KRS 211.350(8))

Sequence the build around those two. Temporary construction power is expressly not blocked — *"nothing in this section shall prohibit the supply or use of necessary electrical services during the construction and testing process"* — so arrange it early and separately. (KRS 198B.060(11); KRS 318.165)

THE BUILDING INSPECTIONS — IF YOUR JURISDICTION REQUIRES THEM

Where a local ordinance applies, the sequence below is the one Kentucky building departments commonly call for a new house. It is a **working sequence, not a statutory list** — Kentucky does not fix one in statute for single-family dwellings. Confirm yours against your permit card at the first inspection and write in anything your jurisdiction adds.

Working residential sequence where a local ordinance applies

Inspection	What must be complete
1. Footing	Trenches excavated to depth, forms and reinforcing in place, before concrete.

Working residential sequence where a local ordinance applies

Inspection	What must be complete
2. Foundation / waterproofing	After the walls are poured or laid and damp-proofing is applied — before backfill. Backfilling early is the commonest way to lose this one.
3. Under-slab	Under-slab plumbing and any under-slab electrical, plus the vapor retarder and fill, before the slab is poured.
4. Rough-ins	Plumbing, electrical and HVAC rough-in. In Kentucky these are frequently different inspectors from different governments than the building inspector — book them separately and early.
5. Framing	After the roof is on and all framing, firestopping and bracing are in place. Most jurisdictions want the rough-ins approved first; ask yours whether it is a requirement or a preference.
6. Insulation	After framing is approved and before any wall or ceiling covering, to the 2009 IECC as adopted.
7. Finals	Each trade takes its own final. The building final is the one that releases the certificate of occupancy where one is issued.

Steps above carry no citation because Kentucky prescribes no statutory inspection sequence for a single-family dwelling — these are common practice, and your jurisdiction's card governs. Energy provisions: 2009 IECC for residential buildings, per the Department's currently-adopted code list.

THE CLOCKS AND RIGHTS KENTUCKY GIVES YOU

Kentucky hands owner-builders several genuine rights that almost nobody invokes, mostly because they are scattered across three chapters.

- **Your HVAC inspection runs on a statutory clock.** It *"shall be scheduled with the property owner or owners or their agent or agents **at least one (1) business day in advance** and shall be **completed within three (3) business days** of the scheduled inspection."* This is the only hard inspection deadline in the Kentucky residential scheme — hold them to it. (KRS 198B.6672(3))
- **Five plumbing inspections are already paid for.** *"A person with a plumbing permit shall be entitled to five (5) plumbing inspections at no additional cost."* Additional ones are \$50 each — unless your permit cost more than \$250, in which case they are free too. (815 KAR 20:050 §5)
- **An inspector may not overrule your approved drawings.** *"All buildings shall be constructed according to the construction documents approved by the building official ... **No on-site inspector shall order changes in the construction of a building which are contrary to the approved construction documents.**"* If an inspector disagrees with the approved plans, the statute tells them to refer it back to the building official — not to direct you on site. (KRS 198B.062)
- **A fast appeal, with dates attached.** Where a local appeals board exists it must convene a hearing *"within fifteen (15) days of receipt"* of your appeal, notify all parties by certified mail *"no later than ten (10) days prior,"* and *"render a decision within five (5)*

working days after the hearing." Its decision can then be appealed to the Department. (KRS 198B.070(3), (4))

• **An HVAC refusal is appealable too** — an applicant aggrieved by an action of an inspector or the Department *"may request a hearing in accordance with KRS Chapter 13B."* (KRS 198B.6677(2))

What Kentucky does NOT promise you

There is **no statutory deadline** for a building, plumbing or electrical inspector to attend after you request an inspection — the three-business-day rule reaches HVAC only. There is no statutory permit-decision clock for a single-family dwelling either. Ask each office what to expect, write it into KY.4, and book further ahead than feels necessary.

And note what applying costs you: an applicant *"by the act of applying for the permit, shall be deemed to have consented to inspection ... during construction and upon the completion of construction."* Refusing an inspection has consequences of its own — for HVAC the inspector *"shall refuse to approve the work"* and continued use of the system can be prohibited outright. (KRS 198B.060(9); KRS 198B.6677(1))

THE CERTIFICATE AT THE END — OPTIONAL, AND WORTH HAVING

Where a local government has established jurisdiction, no building may be occupied until the building official issues a **certificate of occupancy**. Where it has not, nothing *"shall be construed to require a certificate of occupancy to be issued for any single-family dwelling."* So for much of Kentucky the certificate is genuinely optional.

Get one anyway if you can. Kentucky attaches a specific financial consequence to not having one. Anyone damaged by a violation of the code may sue whoever committed it — within one year of discovering the damage, and in no event more than ten years after first occupation or the settlement date. The award may include damages and the cost of litigation, and ***"if a certificate of occupancy was not issued, then an award may also include reasonable attorney's fees."*** A certificate you were never required to obtain is the cheapest liability insurance available to a Kentucky owner-builder.

If your jurisdiction issues one, note that any approved change to the construction *"shall be recorded with the construction documents before the certificate of occupancy shall be issued"* — so keep your change records with the plan set rather than loose.

KRS 198B.060(13); KRS 198B.130(1), (2); KRS 198B.062.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory, and note **which office** each inspection came from — in Kentucky that is genuinely not the same one each time. If no building inspector ever attends your site, this page and your photographs are the only record that the work was done to code. Take the photographs regardless.

Inspection log

Inspection	Office	Called	Held	Result	Corrections required / notes
Footing					
Foundation					
Under-slab					
Plumbing rough					
Electrical rough					
HVAC installation					
Framing					
Insulation					
Plumbing final					
Electrical final certificate					
HVAC final					
Building final					

Electrical final certificate of approval issued: _____ Permanent power set: _____

Plumbing final approved: _____ Permanent water set: _____

Certificate of occupancy issued (or N/A): _____ Number: _____

Sources (verified August 2026; statutes and regulations at apps.legislature.ky.gov). HVAC inspection scheduling and completion — KRS 198B.6672(3). Refusal to approve, and the right to a hearing — KRS 198B.6677. Deemed consent to inspection — KRS 198B.060(9). Permanent electric service and the certified electrical inspector — KRS 198B.060(11). Permanent water supply — KRS 318.165. Five plumbing inspections included — 815 KAR 20:050 Section 5(1). Approved construction documents and on-site inspectors — KRS 198B.062. Appeal clocks — KRS 198B.070(3), (4). Certificate of occupancy not required for a single-family dwelling absent a local program — KRS 198B.060(13). Private action and attorney's fees — KRS 198B.130. Steps without a citation are common practice, not law — confirm them locally.